

Shashi Tharoor's Talk

A Well-Educated Mind vs A Well-Formed Mind

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Introduction

- Shashi Tharoor discusses the state of higher education by pointing out that India has a remarkably young population that needs urgent reform.
- He begins with **demographics**: India is a very **young country**.
 - 65% of Indians are under 35.
 - Half of the population is under 25.
 - The age group 10–19 has 226 million people who are soon entering higher education.
- The average age of India is 28–29, while countries like Japan, China, and US are much older (40+).
- This gives India a chance to use its **youth power** to lead the world.
- But if India fails to educate/train them, this “demographic dividend” can become a **demographic disaster** (youth frustration, violence, Maoism, etc.).
- So, Education in our country is not a social or economic issue, but a national security issue.

The Four E's of Education

Tharoor explains 4 main priorities:

1. **Expansion**
 - At Independence, the British left us with: 16% literacy, 26 universities, <700 colleges, and only 4 lakh students.
 - Today: 74% literacy, 650 universities, 35,000 colleges, 2 crore students.
 - So expansion has happened, but still not enough.
2. **Equity**
 - Many groups were left out: women, lower castes, poor regions, and religions.
 - Female literacy at independence was only 8.9% (1 in 11 women could read and write).
 - Inclusion has improved, but challenges remain.
3. **Excellence**
 - Some world-class institutions exist (IITs, IIMs, etc.).
 - But most universities are average or below average.
 - India has “islands of excellence floating in a sea of mediocrity.”
4. **Employability**
 - If We talk to the CEO they tell us that they are simply not satisfied with the quality of graduates they are getting.(64% of the employers are not happy with the graduates they are getting)
 - Even engineers often need extra training after being hired. Eg. The great Giant Infosys has a training centre in Mysore for this.
 - Employers complain about the poor quality of skills.

- Shashi Tharoor was born in 1956, the same year when Jawaharlal Nehru transformed the British detention center at Hijli into IIT Kharagpur, turning a symbol of political oppression into a symbol of hope and progress.
- Through the Right to Education (RTE) Act, 2009, which mandated free and compulsory education for children aged 6 to 14, the Indian government has attempted to increase access to education. State universities now receive more funding, and community colleges that combine academics and practical skills were established, along with adult literacy initiatives. People who are literate gain self-assurance and independence.
- For instance, Chitra Mani from Tamil Nadu was able to travel independently after learning to read. Although women's literacy has increased from 9% in 1947 to roughly 66% today, one-third of them are still illiterate. The Gross Enrollment Ratio for India shows both progress and dropout rates. Compared to a primary enrolment rate of 116%, it drops to 69% by class 8, 39% by class 10, and only 18% at the college level.

Innovation and Thinking

- India is renowned for its jugaad, such as the TATA Nano, insulin injection, and the least expensive ECG. True innovation, however, entails the creation of new things, such as ancient Nalanda giving the world "zero."
- **Issue:** India produces only 2.8% of the world's research output despite having 17% of the world's brains.
- **Cause:** Education aims to instil knowledge in students' minds. However, facts are readily available in the era of the Internet.
- A well-developed mind must be able to:
 - 1) Respond to new information
 - 2) Understand and think creatively
 - 3) Face obstacles in life, not just in the classroom
 - 4) Ask not just "Why?" but also "Why not?"
- For instance, his glasses issue. For him, traditional design always breaks. A friend made new glasses with magnets in the centre. This demonstrates creative thinking.

Conclusion

- Literacy, equity, quality, and employability need to be enhanced in India.
- Good news: 95% of 12-year-olds in India can read and write today.
- If India educates its youth adequately, it will be the world's workforce.
- Tharoor concludes on a positive note: "If we get all these pieces right, we can tell the world – we are coming."